

Personal Policy Problem

Overview

Over the course of the semester, students will complete a comprehensive memo on a personal policy problem (PPP) of professional interest and relevance. The learning objectives for the PPP are: 1) to provide practical grounding for the course's instruction on the theory of policy analysis and evaluation; 2) to allow students to think concretely about the course concepts in the context of an issue of personal significance, and; 3) to hone professional memo writing and analysis skills.

PPP Workshopping Process

Students will have time during course seminars to discuss PPP topics with a pre-assigned small group of classmates. Students will be informed of their group assignments the first week of classes. Students are encouraged to provide feedback to their PPP small group members outside of class as well. The PGTAs will be available during office hours every week to discuss students' topic and how to think through the key elements of the memo assignment.

Formatting Elements

The PPP memo should capture all of the same elements outlined in the attached template below. Students are expected to cite sources using endnotes, which will not count against the page total.

In addition, students are required to include a one page cover letter that might include additional context about the authorizer or the drafter that would help evaluate the memo.

Template

Issue

Your memo should start with a concise statement of the issue. The issue statement is essentially what Bardach refers to as a problem definition. It may range from a few words to a few sentences, depending upon the decision-maker's existing familiarity with the issue.

Stakeholders

This section of the memo should outline prominent stakeholders and their interests. It should include a concise analysis of major stakeholders' motivations, beliefs, and resources. If the decision-maker herself has important interests that are not already obvious, this is the place to raise them (though it is *not* the place for lobbying or advocacy.) This section should equip the decision-maker with a practical grasp of what's politically feasible.

Analysis

This section—which is distinct from the subsequent analysis of policy options—should outline the critical drivers of the issue and equip the reader to understand key dynamics and areas of risk and opportunity. Its length and degree of detail will depend upon the decision-maker's existing familiarity with the issue area. Avoid filling this section with background information that your reader would likely already know.

Criteria

Your criteria should include the advancement of core policy goals—whether opportunities to be seized or problems to be avoided. Other criteria include aspects of operational (legal, financial, technical) or political (legislative, public opinion, organizational politics) feasibility. Your list of criteria should be as compact as possible, but should lay the groundwork for flagging pros and cons of policy options.

Options

This section identifies and analyzes alternative approaches to addressing the issue. In professional practice the appropriate number of options will vary. The standard tends towards three distinct options, normally including some version of “continue current policy.” You should project the outcomes of each option and identify the main pros and cons of each, stated in terms of the criteria laid out earlier. It can be useful to create memorable titles for each option, but make sure these titles are descriptive of the option’s content.

Recommendation

In a short statement, clearly provide the reader with your recommended option and a short explanation of the rationale.

Risks and Uncertainties

Important risks will often remain even at the end of an exhaustive policy development process, and for a preliminary effort—such as most Personal Policy Problems—there will be profound uncertainties. This is the place to alert the decision-maker to key unknowns relevant to your analysis and recommendation. It can be helpful to reflect on the categories of value, operational capacity, and political feasibility as you zero in on the most important risks and uncertainties and the evidence and methods you would use in to deal with them in the next iteration

of the policy process. Use your judgment to avoid ill-serving the decision-maker through either presenting *everything* as too uncertain to offer any recommendation, or suggesting unwarranted confidence in your analysis of the underlying issue or the outcomes of your favored option.

Implementation

The implementation section should offer actions steps to carry out your recommended option. Make sure to clearly identify the who, what, when, where, so the decision-maker will know what to do if she agrees with your recommendation. These steps should build upon, rather than re-stating, your options analysis. While most policy memos should address both uncertainties and implementation, the relative importance of these sections will vary depending on the stage of the policy process, with early-stage memos devoting more attention to de-risking and later-stage memos focusing more on implementation.

Again, policy memo writing is a craft and not a science. Some of the above sections may be longer, shorter or even omitted depending on your circumstances. You have a finite amount of real estate - typically two pages - how you use that space involves significant judgment.